

Little Kings, Big Criminals, and Borderlessness on Bengal's Northern Frontier

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Abstract

This article argues that the East India Company did not rapidly impose a Europeanized model of territorial sovereignty on Bengal's northern borderlands. Rather, in late eighteenth- and early nineteenth-century Rangpur district, it inhabited a vibrant political landscape shaped by Mughal-era tributary practices, competing claims by surrounding states, mobile military markets, refugees, bandits and minor rajas with big ambitions. It reconstructs the deep context behind the Company's first major intervention into the region, a 1792 expedition by Thomas Welsh, showing how the episode exemplified the "pull effect" of the Bengal frontier as the Company attempted to tamp down on quests for wealth and power by local actors. By showing frontier governance as reactive and shallow, the article ties into a broader reconsideration in imperial history of the transformative capacity of the early colonial state, as well as the relative weighting of precolonial patterns and the agency of non-European actors.

Keywords

Rangpur; Bengal borderlands; East India Company; sovereignty; Assam; Welsh expedition

Introduction

This article examines East India Company governance on Bengal's northern frontier in the late 18th and early 19th centuries. Its purpose is to demonstrate the extent to which, rather than rapidly remaking this borderland according to a Europeanized blueprint artificially crystallizing the relationship between territory and sovereignty in the region, the colonial state was perched on top of and reacting to a still vibrant and highly fluid political and social landscape whose contours originated in the precolonial period.

The most current trend in the historiography of the northeast frontier of India is a postcolonial one that has systematically worked to dismantle the enduring grip of nationalist intellectual frameworks on scholarly understanding of it (Cederlöf 2013; Misra 2005, 2011, 2018, 2021; Zou and Kumar 2011; Baruah 2008; Ludden 2003). Most of these studies work within a paradigm pioneered by scholars of Southeast Asia who, since the end of the colonial period, have sought to highlight the inadequacies of the concepts of the nation and the nation-state when applied to the precolonial past (Leach 1960, 1965; Lehman 1963; Scott 2009; Winichakul 1994; van Schendel 2002; Guha 1999; Lattimore 1962). They have pointed to a lack of overlap between territory, sovereignty and ethnicity across the whole of this frontier in the precolonial period - these being the three ingredients that, when they cohere (or can be made to cohere by modern governments), form the geographical extent and popular basis for the exercise of a nation-state's power (Mullaney 2012).

Such studies tend to emphasize the radically transformative impact of European imperialism as the main driver for why ambiguous and open-ended precolonial patterns came to an end. At the same time as the colonial state was entering into these borderlands and desirous of remolding them according to a more stringent sovereignty paradigm, it produced a raft of new information that acted to conceptualize the region along the same lines, intellectually transforming it on paper at the same time as it administratively reordered it on the ground (Kar 2012; Misra 2005, 2011, 2018; Zou and Kumar 2011; Pau 2018; Baruah 2008; Cederlöf 2013; Ludden 2003).

I use this literature as a point of departure, sharing its skeptical reading of the nation as a valid analytical category for studying the precolonial pasts of South and Southeast Asia. However, rather than focusing on the bureaucratic regime and forms of administrative knowledge imposed on the region by the colonial state and their subsequent transformative impact, I turn to the earliest manifestations of colonialism in the region in the late 18th and early 19th centuries, asking questions about the nature and extent of the influence of precolonial social and political structures, power dynamics, and knowledge systems on early colonial rule.

I adopt a bottom-up approach, treating the colonial state not as a monolithic and hegemonic presence in the region, but as a meta-state: a small, Weberian bureaucracy resting on top of a variety of precolonial social and political structures, interacting with powerful local actors in a negotiated and contingent manner. By foregrounding the intersection between the pre and early colonial, I hope to show that the early colonial state did not immediately mark a sharp and radical rupture with past dynamics but rather was thoroughly entangled with them.

In highlighting the limited, decentralized nature of the early colonial state, which resulted in the survival of many of the patterns characterizing the region in the precolonial period well into the 19th century, I am influenced by C. A. Bayly, P. J. Marshall and others who have all in different ways reacted to a widespread tendency in the historiography on European imperialism to overestimate the extent and transformative impact of colonial power (Marshall 1987, 2003; Bayly 1988, 2012; Perlin 1985). They have sought to demonstrate that the EIC's ascent to power in India was rooted partly in historical trends emanating from Europe, but partly in those of the subcontinent itself, and that the form colonialism was able to take during the 18th and first half of the 19th centuries was determined in large part by the ways in which it interacted with political, economic and social patterns long predating it. Scholarship along these lines has produced work demonstrating the limited reach of colonial governance on British India's frontiers (Simpson 2021; Benton 2010; Robb 1997; Cederlöf 2013). I add to this growing set of voices by showing that in Rangpur, the colonial state's weakness and neglect produced if anything an even stronger effect along these lines: the most important drivers of the following events were largely non-European actors, and the patterns that drove them were often precolonial in origin, in some cases persisting well into the 19th century (Mackenzie 1884; Pau 2021).

The northeast frontier of Bengal was not a place conducive to the expansion of imperial power. Even the late imperial state in its full flower exercised only shifting and unsystematic control over the region, a pattern that becomes more acute the earlier the date. This shallow, passing presence was to an extent produced by simple inability to project power, but partly also by design - the EIC's interests in the region

were limited and it paid only as much attention as was necessary to secure them (Cederlöf 2013, chs. 3, 5, 6). Complex challenges and limited goals combined to produce a weak, contested administration, characterized not by rational institutionalization, but by a series of disconnected attempts to attach the sinews of the colonial state to pre-existing structures - entering into tributary relations with local rulers, taking control of foreign and military affairs, securing revenues, promoting trade, grabbing control of key resources and otherwise interfering as little as possible in local governance.

The Company's relative disinterest and shallow presence in these borderlands allowed for much of the mobility, hybridity and overlap that had characterized them in the precolonial period to continue unabated into the early 19th century. District officials remained engaged in precolonial sovereignty arrangements with minor tributary rulers, who themselves could be beholden to larger neighbors, often more than one simultaneously. There were no properly demarcated borders or evenly distributed mechanisms to control movements of people, so they circulated across the region uninhibited. The Company was unable to monopolize violence, which meant that in these lightly governed spaces, claimants from many backgrounds arose whose use of coercion in the quest for wealth and power took on a series of morphing forms, from simple banditry to the outright assertion of statehood; the most physically intractable spaces, which were often populated by the groups least amenable to having state power exercised over them, were almost uniformly ignored. The colonial state, at least this incarnation of it, was not able to superimpose on the territory it controlled in a cookie-cutter way European statecraft norms. The period in question marks the beginning of its ambitions to reorder the region along these lines, but this was aspirational; in reality it was still presiding over basically the same mode of frontier governance that had been put in place by the Mughals (Eaton 1993; van Schendel 2009).

The earliest concerted intervention into the region was the Welsh expedition, a military mission sent into Assam in 1792 under Captain Thomas Welsh, tasked with collecting information on a little-known region of the world, assisting the Ahom monarch against breakaway factions, and tamping down on the movement of mercenaries into the conflict from Bengal. I demonstrate how this intervention grew out of the survival of patterns of overlapping and divided sovereignty, human mobility and a freewheeling interstate military market. The complex, interlocking nature of borderland politics, the spillover of the conflict into Bengal, the multifaceted power struggles taking place immediately before the dispatch of the expedition, and attempts by its players to use the Company for their ends - all were "pull" factors contributing to the growth of the EIC's behemoth but discombobulated state, which according to David Ludden, "never articulated a centralized process of imperial fusion," and yet expanded continuously in bits and pieces due to localized activity not under central control (Ludden 2011, 140; Galbraith 1960).

The article is divided into three parts. The first looks at what kind of administration the Company set up in Rangpur district, how it interacted with the many minor principalities to its north, lodged between it and Bhutan, Assam and Nepal, and to what extent it monopolized violence and controlled its borders. In section two, I consider the interconnectedness of northern Bengal and Assam, showing how state breakdown there had major ripple effects across the region, attracting large numbers of bandits and mercenaries from across India, which in turn attracted the attention of

the Company's highest officials. Section three chronicles the deliberations leading up to the decision to dispatch a military expedition to Assam in order to rectify what the Company believed was a major gap in its projection of sovereignty, leading to the establishment of its first, fleeting footprint in the kingdom.

Divided and Overlapping Sovereignty on Rangpur's Northern Border

The EIC's initial footprint in Rangpur district, the northernmost district of Bengal bordering on Assam, was light. The Company had little presence there until the 1770s, and when its servants did arrive to govern, they started from an information-less state, building up a picture of the district's revenue history through oral interviews with officials of the previous regime (Glazier 1876, Appendix C). They were at first primarily concerned with taxing large landowners and control of the cloth industry around the Company's factory settlement, reflecting the narrow concerns of the early Company (Glazier 1873, 16-20). This rudimentary administration had a heavily circumscribed ecumene. It was acting in a supervisory capacity, watching over the infrastructure of government that had been put in place by the nawabs to ensure that its most basic needs were met, namely the upward flow of resources and the maintenance of basic military and police powers.

The northern fringe of Rangpur district was home to a number of petty states ruled by princes of Tibeto-Burman tribal origin. The Mughals in the 17th century had established loose tributary relations with many of these princes, representing them in their records as zamindars, a general category into which many different kinds of landowners were subsumed (Richards 1993; Eaton 1993, 186-193). Early Company administration in Rangpur relied on Mughal records, and on Mughal-trained officials literate in Persian, to perform the business of governance; as such, when these princes are mentioned at all in early records, it tends to be in the context of Mughal-era tribute quotas (Glazier 1873, 66-67). In these documents, there is little recognition of their ethnic difference, or of their sovereign status, merely of a one-dimensional economic relation.

Some level of increased definition regarding patterns of frontier landownership came into view with the Permanent Settlement, a new system of taxation meant to fix rates on land in perpetuity and hold defaulting landlords accountable by auctioning off their property (Guha 1982). As the author of a mid-19th century history of Rangpur district put it, efforts to fix in place a regularized system of revenue extraction led to the discovery that the term zamindar was:

...a very wide one, including different classes of owners, the origin of whose rights was very various. Thus, in Rungpore, we have what, for want of better terms, may be styled the semi-feudatory estates, such as Bykuntpore and the Chaklas, held by the Rajah of Cooch Behar; the sub-feudatory of the rest of Coochwara, held by descendants of Cooch Behar officers, who had a century before been inducted by the Moguls into their estates as zemindars; the new purchasers, such as Baharbund and Sorooppore, who could pretend to no rights beyond any limitations the Government might have chosen to have entered in their deeds of possession; the large zemindars, owners of what had been principalities, such as Edrakpore and Dinagepore; and lastly, the

smaller ones, which were generally holders of talooks, which had been separate from the larger estates (Glazier 1873, 36).

This layered system of settlements, each with differing tenury rights, was the result of multiple conquests stacked on top of each other, of which the Company's was only the latest. The earliest layer was made up of the fragments of the Koch state, which had been carved out of the local tribal population through processes of ethnic melding, sedentarization, Hinduization and the establishment of interrelated aristocratic lineages controlling a variety of settlements which were linked together in hierarchical political relations. Koch Behar's three larger neighbors in Assam, Bhutan and Mughal Bengal had all successively launched invasions of the area, eating away at the integrity of those political relationships and eventually unwinding them completely, so that by the late 18th century, Koch rajas were no longer strongly connected to each other, but rather had been incorporated into the political systems of these other states as isolated clients (Sinha 1987; Barpujari 2007, vol. 2, chs. 4-6; Barooah 1970, 22-37; Field 1962). Scattered among these rested another stratum of zamindars that had overseen the process of Mughal colonization of the region; these had significant independent power themselves, often sitting at the center of networks of lesser landholders. The most recent layer was made up of revenue farmers appointed by the Company, who were state functionaries with no independent rights.

The Permanent Settlement only brought some of these Koch rajas into more definite relationships with the government; others continued to exist only half within the Company's domains at least until the early 19th century. The revenues of estates that had formerly paid regularized land taxes to the Mughals were fixed in place, but distant peripheral states that had only loosely been incorporated into the Mughal system, and who paid tribute in kind or nothing at all, were left out. This jagged, fragmented collection of principalities remained in a state of sovereign limbo for decades. Because of this, as the author of an internal report on affairs in the district in the 1810s wrote, the shape of the district was so "exceedingly irregular and staggering as to bid defiance to all verbal description," which he explained was due to the fact that it lacked any natural boundaries in mountains or rivers, and bordered on five different political entities - the Garo hills, Nepal, Sikkim, Koch Behar and Bhutan, all of which were engaged in vigorous diplomatic and military contestation over control of resources and people along the border (IOR/F/4/533/12847, August 19, 1815).

Alexander Hamilton, a popular geographer of the period, described the situation thusly:

The present possessions of Bootan to the south-west are separated from the Bengal districts by the river Teesta, as far south as Gopaulgunge...To the south of this point the British territories cross the Teesta, and intermix with those of Bootan in a most irregular manner, the line of boundary in this quarter being altogether imaginary. Portions of territory belonging to each state are completely insulated by the possessions of the other, as exemplified in the extensive tract named Phulacotta, which lies to the west of the Teesta, and is completely surrounded by the Bengalese zemindary of Bykantpoor, without any intelligible or even perceptible land marks. The retention of Phulacotta, however, is attended with such lucrative advantages to the Subah of Dellamcotta and the local officers, that no hopes are

entertained of being able to effect its purchase or exchange for some other space of adequate value (Hamilton 1820, 733-734).

These sovereignty relationships emerged from rival claims being made over them simultaneously by the Company and by Bhutan and Nepal, both of which operated smaller but locally important imperial systems in the trans-Himalayan region. One such claim stemmed from a 1772 war in which the Bhutanese had invaded and conquered Coch Behar and many of its associated principalities. The Coch raja petitioned the Company for aid, which resulted in a counteroffensive that pushed the Bhutanese army back into the mountains. Coch Behar was thereafter under nominal Company authority, but the war did not produce any conclusive territorial boundary. Rather, the whole line of frontier, Hamilton wrote, was subject to regular "encroachment" by the Bhutanese (Hamilton 1820, 733-734), who had annexed multiple minor states nominally under the control of the Company.

One focal point of these rival sovereignty claims was the Koch principality of Bidyagong, lately wrested away from the Company's control by Bhutan. According to Hamilton: "The Bidyagong estate was originally obliged to deliver annually 40 elephants to the British government, which last as the feudal superior had the sole right of nominating to the succession. It is true that the Bidyagong chief gave the Bootanners, yearly, about 400 rupees worth of cotton cloths and dried fish, but this was done merely to conciliate the good will of a tribe, which, from its position, was always able to harass his estate." When the Bhutanese penetrated into Bidyagong and reoriented it towards them, the EIC did nothing, as it was of "trivial importance." When the Company did protest in correspondence with the ruler of Bhutan, arguing that he needed documentary evidence of his right to the territory in order to take control of it, the reply came that "it was not customary for the Bootanners to be regulated by writings but by possession" - a rejection of the whole framework of bureaucratic governance practiced by the Company (Hamilton 1820, 733-734).

Another example of the EIC's engagement in these kinds of indeterminate sovereignty relationships includes Bykuntpore, another Koch statelet, whose territories were "indented," as Francis Sisson, a surveyor of the area wrote, with villages controlled by Bhutan. The Bykuntpore raja controlled estates entirely within Bhutanese territory, and Bhutan controlled the estate of Phulacotta, fully enclosed on all sides by Bykuntpore. On his questioning local people as to the whereabouts of the boundary, they pointed to seemingly random features, which he could not make sense of, leading him to conclude that it existed only in the "fertility of imagination." His poring over earlier Company records suggested to him a reason for this: that after the Company's 1770s war with Bhutan, both had agreed in the peace treaty to restore the region to its former state and give up all conquered possessions, but the Bhutanese had successfully represented many of its new acquisitions as customarily under its control, which the Company turned a blind eye to as part of a pivot to courting the Bhutan government in the hopes that it could link Bengal to Tibet through Bhutan's trade routes (IOR/F/4/533/12847, August 19, 1815).

Nor did Bykuntpore have a proper boundary with Sikkim or Nepal. Sisson described the boundary as demarcated by a river only part ways, after which it cut through open country where it existed only in the minds of local inhabitants, then into jungle where even local inhabitants ventured no guesses. The Bykuntpore raja, he said, laid claim to all the forests and wilds up to the hills, while the Nepali authorities

controlled Sikkim, and through Sikkim, laid claim to all the forests down to its southernmost reaches - the Sikkim moroung, or adjacent lowlands. He reconciled these two incompatible claims by reasoning that likely the Nepalese were making the aggressive moves, and that the older claim was probably Bykantpore's, as the raja's family had once resided in the middle of the forest, but had since moved southward to avoid the Gurkhas; he cautioned that this was speculation, and that likely the tract changed hands depending on which claimants were strongest at any given time (IOR/F/4/533/12847, August 19, 1815).

Another Koch state under shared sovereignty was Bijnee, which remained largely unknown to the Company until a political event brought it sharply into focus. As Hamilton explained: "In consequence of their remote situation," he wrote, "and the general wildness of the country, the history of the Estates in this quarter was long but imperfectly known, even to the public functionaries at Rungpoor, and so long as the Bijnee Raja paid the customary tribute, no inquiry was made as to the state of the country, or even to ascertain the original nature of his connection with the Mogul Emperor, to whose authority the British government had succeeded" (Hamilton 1820, 753).

The government in Calcutta only began to pay attention to Bijnee after its raja was kidnapped and murdered, which embroiled the EIC in a conflict with Bhutan over who had the right to install the next one. The Bhutanese acted first, appointing a new raja who, with the aid of his patrons, gathered an army and militarily occupied the territory (Hamilton 1820, 753-756; Hamilton 1828, 241-244; IOR/F/4/533/12847, August 19, 1815).

The Bhutanese position on this conflict was outlined in a letter written by the marcher lord overseeing it. He wrote that the Bhutanese considered themselves the lords of Bijnee on equal status with the Company, and that the two were supposed to share the duties of arbitrating justice there. He believed the Company had failed in this, either ordering the kidnapping of the raja and the theft of his property or protecting those who had done so. He demanded that the raja and his treasure be returned, or he would sweep down into the plains, plundering the zamindars and taking captives. "Whether I can convey them or not to the hills you shall afterwards see," the letter concludes pointedly (Glazier 1873, 93-94).

Only after the receipt of this ominous reproach did the Company make a serious inquiry into Bijnee, which found that the principality had long been subject to two masters, simultaneously paying tribute both to the Company and to Bhutan. It had a fixed, two-way trade with its northern suzerain, which provided horses and salt in return for a much larger annual shipment of cloth, cotton, silver and other articles. The results of these inquiries peeled back the veil on the Company's long participation in the snarled tangle of sovereignty arrangements prevailing in Bijnee. On the south side of the river, the Bijnee raja fell under the umbrella of Company sovereignty. In his capacity as a Bhutanese official on the northern side of the river, he ruled in concert with the Bhutanese state, referring high criminal cases to its representatives for approval and paying annual tribute. The main settlement, crowned by the raja's fortress, was a kind of "neutral ground," Hamilton wrote, "so that although he has a guard of Bootanners, and also some sepoy, whom he probably represents as belonging to the English, the officers of neither government interfere at Bijnee, where he is said to harbour many suspicious characters, and even to participate in their plunder" (Hamilton 1820, 754). The Company unilaterally

determined that the right of appointing the next raja belonged to them. In what was likely an attempt at conciliation, however, it also conveniently announced that the Bhutanese candidate was in fact the best one, retroactively confirming him in an office he had already seized by force.

The disintegration of political authority in Assam had a major impact on the social life of Bijnee, which was flooded by refugees that had significantly swelled its population. These lived on both sides of the river, maintaining cultivation in areas previously governed by Assam, but keeping their families on the Company side because it was less dangerous (Buchanan 2017, 35-36). Such cultivators were well-adapted to protecting themselves in an insecure space. They were only intermittently sedentary, moving from place to place to avoid roving armies, bands of decommissioned soldiers and thieves. The raja and his servants, afraid of losing the tax wealth they represented, were suspected of employing coercive methods to keep them in reach.

The anomalous status of Bijnee attracted a variety of people who had an interest in keeping themselves out of the hands of neighboring states. Bandits and mercenaries, seeking opportunity in the political vacuum caused by state breakdown in Assam, frequently moved through the principality (Hamilton 1828, 77; IOR/F/4/533/12847, August 19, 1815). The activities of these figures occupied a vague space between the realms of criminality and politics. One was Gholaum Ali Beg, a Muslim mercenary from north India who had been employed by the Assamese to fight the Moamarias. On refusing to take a pay cut and being summarily dismissed without payment, he and his band of followers turned to banditry, taking up residence in Bijnee, raiding into both Assam and Bengal, plundering merchant vessels on the Brahmaputra, and attacking and looting customs posts which were filled with so much treasure that even his foot soldiers became rich; twelve of them were arrested in EIC domains carrying thousands of rupees. He acquired a "kind of sovereignty over 16 villages, on the eastern bank of the Manas, from which he received a large revenue, readily paid by the inhabitants for protection; but he was at length vanquished by another body of freebooters, led by a Hindustany Rajpoot, named Manick Ray," who drove him into Bhutan and took over his hideout (IOR/F/4/533/12847, August 19, 1815).

The activities of Manick Ray also bled into regional politics. From the roost he had seized from his predecessor, he plundered trade caravans and raided surrounding areas with relative impunity. EIC sepoys were forbidden from crossing borders to arrest him, and the Bijnee raja was suspected of concealing his activities in return for a cut of his profits. Ray was accused of engaging in a kind of micro-imperialism by the king of Assam, who wrote a letter to the Company claiming that he could not repay his debts to European merchants across the border because: "From the eastward and northward the people of Nura, Khamti, Dopla, and Mahamari, had assembled and invaded his dominions; while on the Bijnee frontier, a robber, named Manick Ray, had made repeated inroads, laid waste three pergunnahs, and plundered the custom-house of Kandari." Both Ray and his predecessor were also courted by an Ahom prince, Brajanath, an exiled claimant to the throne, who hoped to use their forces to spearhead an attempt to gain power, though the opposite seems to have happened, in that Brajanath's followers melted away to join the bandits (IOR/F/4/533/12847, August 19, 1815).

The Company's relationship with Bijnee encapsulates a much wider pattern: its continued participation in pre-colonial patterns of frontier governance all across

Rangpur district in the late 18th and early 19th centuries. Its footprint in the region was extremely light and oriented towards loose, high-level political control in the service of resource extraction from layers of intermediary rulers. The district effectively had no border but instead was home to a fragmentary group of Koch principalities over which multiple neighboring states made a variety of overlapping and contested claims to sovereignty and resource rights, and through which people and goods flowed largely unrestricted. This open space allowed for expression of a variety of social and political dynamics that the Company would rather not have tolerated, including: smuggling, refugee flows, banditry, roving mercenary bands, and full-scale military encounters between third party actors occurring on its claimed territory. But it had little ability to influence the course of events, as it was not a modern, sovereign state, but a trading corporation that had loosely grabbed hold of the reins of power in Bengal and was only beginning to formulate plans to establish control at the ground level in remote frontier regions.

Lawlessness and Minor Kingship in Rangpur District

For decades after the Company's ascent to power in Bengal, it operated no police force at all. In Rangpur district, police duties were at first undertaken by local potentates, who employed guards at markets to collect duties and arrest thieves as they had done under the previous regime; the EIC's actions in this regard were limited to posting bounties on the heads of major bandit leaders and tracking them down with army contingents. By the 1790s, the erosion of traditional sources of authority, hastened by the "predatory phase of colonial rule," had combined with agrarian crisis to produce rural violence (both banditry and explicitly anti-state rebellion) on such a large scale that the Company was forced to step in, both to assert a right to a monopoly of force and to ensure that revenue flows were not impacted (Chatterji 1981, 19-26).

Rangpur district, which had been the site of a major peasant uprising (Wilson 2005, 81-109), was one of the focal points of this effort, though it seems to have been largely unsuccessful, one mid-19th century chronicler describing it as "splendid but utopian," before going on to describe various instances of corruption, incompetence, stonewalling of investigations, insurrection and mob justice, besides accusing the police of primarily protecting the rich and ignoring the rest of the population (Glazier 1876, 3-5). Reports on the state of policing in the district, compiled in 1814 and 1815, shed some light on the reasons why: the district had dispersed settlement patterns, making individual homesteads vulnerable to attack; there was a prevalence of wilderness for bandits to hide in; internal boundaries within the district made little sense and the jurisdictions of various forces were unclear; and lack of borders and proximity to multiple adjacent states allowed fugitives to slip out of reach at will (IOR/F/4/533/12847, August 19, 1815).

The reports suggested deeply ingrained corruption among the local police, most of whom were from other parts of India and were suspected of having little connection to or sympathy for local people. Such police, according to Sisson, could not be disciplined as they were posted far away from their commanders. They were accused of being slow to take action, loaning money to local people at usurious rates and violently recouping debts, falsifying crimes in order to collect bribes (including allegedly treating suicides as murders in order to blackmail bereaved family members) and engaging in outright banditry, intimidating entire villages into submission by demanding payments while drawn up in full battle formation. Sisson

concluded that local people avoided the police at all costs, that they were the “scourges of the districts” they worked in, and that the system as it stood should be totally scrapped and replaced with a more localized one in which villages levied their own police.

Lawlessness in Rangpur district was so advanced that large caravans of wandering armed groups travelled through it, replete with pack animals, elephants, horses and heavy weaponry in tow like rockets and cannons, making them a formidable military threat (Bhuyan 1949, 277-279). These were often men of military caste from the Gangetic plain, or Afghans; both could be found dispersed throughout north India in the 18th century, where they founded petty principalities, served as mercenaries or turned to robbery - all professions of the gun (Bayly 2012). Networks of Sufi pilgrims, cut off from their previous sources of income by restrictions imposed by the Company, were also active in the area, where they engaged in attacks on the Company, local zamindars, and the population at large (Bhattacharyya 2016, 1-23). Added to this were marauders based in the highlands of Nepal and Bhutan, some of whom were part of clan groups known locally for engaging in a plundering lifestyle, and which became designated as “criminal tribes” under the regime of caste classification that took shape in the later 19th century (Piliavsky 2015). One such group, a “thieving gang, called Kichaks or Godemars...generally looked upon as gipsies, who snared game, told fortunes, and stole as they had opportunity,” were reported to have appeared on the plains in the thousands, looting zamindari estates, even stealing the tribute the Koch Behar raja meant to deliver to the EIC (Glazier 1876, 5-6).

A good example of the extent of the problem is that of two brothers, Sonkar and Mohuntram, who were born in Rangpur but raided from hideouts in both Nepal and Bhutan. They were allies of both the Nepalese and Bhutanese border authorities, who it was suspected afforded them protection (they lived openly in villages just across the border, in plain sight of Company police outposts) in exchange for a cut of their booty. These two men were part of a wider crime wave which tripled instances of robbery in the district, which the Company got hold of by arresting hundreds of people in 1808; but their mountain hideouts made them impervious to this effort. They held out until 1811, together accounting for half the banditry in the district and a number of murders, until they were arrested by police who had to enter Nepal, almost triggering a war. Even after their capture, they were difficult to convict, reportedly bribing and intimidating witnesses (Glazier 1876, 8-9).

Association between these gangs and recognized power-holders was common - armed bands easily doubled as mercenaries or bodyguards, forming a shadowy underworld to local politics (Glazier 1873, 41-43). Bandits were known to forge alliances with powerful landowning patrons who thought they could gain from retaining them (though they were also known to kidnap zamindars and hold them for ransom as well). In some cases such figures, referred to as gunmen or “burkunadzes” in colonial records, had pretensions to legitimate political power, transitioning from plundering to taxation and endeavoring to set themselves up as minor rajas. In other cases landholders abandoned their estates and took to a nomadic, plundering lifestyle, making the line between bandit and landlord unclear (this is reflected in the epithets given to notorious bandits, who were described as sarkars, or rulers).

Such figures regularly appeared on the Company’s payroll. For example in 1789 an EIC officer tracking a group of bandits through a forest on the district’s northern

border (they maintained over twenty garrisons therein, and were well-armed and organized, suggesting that they were possibly a rogue mercenary battalion) reported moving through the forest and fighting several actions, but that the bandits eventually escaped to Nepal and Bhutan, though he managed to capture their leader. His troops consisted of several hundred burkunadzes, mercenaries of the same sort as the men he was hunting (Glazier 1873, 42). The Company used burkunadzes in many other capacities, including for border defense and as bodyguards for merchant trains moving up into war-torn Assam. Many were also veterans of the Company's regular sepoy army - some had been officers in it, and could be found drilling private militias after the fashion of the Company across northeast India (the Company was perennially worried about rumors that they were dressing and presenting themselves as actual Company soldiers) (Bhuyan 1949, chs. 6-8). This was a military market that seamlessly blended into a criminal underworld, and the early Company was one of its principal patrons.

One of the least-governed parts of the Rangpur frontier was around Goalpara, a frontier town that served as the main point of contact with Assam. Goalpara was the conduit for the northward movement of large numbers of wandering hired guns, who were drawn in by the collapse of the Ahom state and its downward spiral into a long, multi-sided war in which mercenaries played an increasingly large role as the kingdom's traditional system of levying conscripts broke down (Buchanan 2017, 22-23). Moving in the other direction were large numbers of refugees fleeing Assam, who settled in Goalpara district, bringing with them their political struggles. Among these refugees were exiled Ahom nobles who brought small armies of retainers with them, bought up weapons in the district, hired more gunmen and crossed back into Assam to continue the fight - actions which the Company sometimes tried to stamp out, and sometimes fostered if it thought that certain figures had a chance of prevailing in the war and becoming clients (Bhuyan 1949, chs. 6, 8).

Goalpara was home to a small European merchant community, among whom the highest prize was achieving a monopoly over the salt trade to Assam, which for many years was in government hands; in the 1790s the government had relinquished its monopoly, leaving the arena open for others to step in. These merchants behaved in many respects like bandits themselves. They employed armed retainers, and were known to use intimidation and violence to recoup their losses. Some were vastly wealthy, building large estates and serving as moneylenders, including to aristocratic clients across the border in Assam (Bhuyan 1949, chs. 2-4; Glazier 1873, 52-53). They were reportedly organized into competing factions, complete with flags and factories; some were suspected of fraudulently representing themselves as operating under the auspices of the Company. In concert with Ahom customs agents across the border, who operated their own monopolies in exchange for passing a cut to the king, cartels on both sides allegedly wielded their power to keep "in awe both the Bengalese and Assamese merchants. The former were only permitted to supply them with what goods they wanted, and to purchase through their hands... Both parties had then very large profits" (Buchanan 2017, 42-45).

The most notorious of these armed merchants was a German named Daniel Rausch, who employed a private band of Portuguese mestizo mercenaries (Martin 1838, 566). He had come under the scrutiny of local officials on multiple occasions for his private use of force - there are accusations on record of him invading Assam, taking an Ahom noble who owed him money prisoner, and killing and plundering at will.

He achieved, allegedly through coercion, a private monopoly over all trade in and out of Assam, forcing the king's customs agents at the border to sign a written agreement to that effect while they were surrounded by his armed guards. Through such actions he not only made a fortune but also became a major player in local politics (IOR/P/114/57, March 16, 1792, nos. 10-12; IOR/P/115/1, March 11, 1793, no. 15). He died as he had lived, murdered in Assam, reportedly at the head of a mercenary band he had led into the kingdom to force the repayment of debts. Ahom aristocrats owed him so much money that the Company spent decades after his death trying to recoup their unpaid debts – an important focal point of later treaty negotiations with the king (Bhuyan 1949, ch. 8).

The small number of Company officials stationed in this lonely town behaved in a manner not wholly different from that of Rausch or other adventurers like him. These officials led bifurcated lives, representing the interests of the Company while simultaneously trying to amass private fortunes, often through surreptitious means. This pattern is best exemplified by the first resident, Hugh Baillie, who convinced the Company to give him a legal trade monopoly over salt. He was accused of coercion and corruption by his own colleagues. After discovering that he was employing burkunadzes, ostensibly on the Company's payroll, to intimidate the Bijnee raja into giving him personal trade concessions, the collector of Rangpur, Richard Goodlad, wrote to him: "I do declare to you that I am so convinced of the injustice and cruelty of the monopoly you are aiming at to the utter ruin of numberless native merchants...that even if the Rajah had given you his consent I would not have admitted of it taking place. Much less will I suffer it when you forcibly attempt to possess yourself of it" (Bhuyan 1949, 141-143). Baillie's self-interested and summary style of government created a number of personal grudges with zamindars in the district, which ended in a violent showdown in which he employed large bands of burkunadzes in a battle with the raja of the border estate of Mechpara, who, paradoxically, fought with decommissioned Company sepoys. Baillie's battle with the man ended with the town of Goalpara being burned to the ground. Afterward he determined it too dangerous to try to disband the mercenary force he had assembled, so he gave it permission to cross the border into Assam. The Company, rather than replacing him, abolished his post completely (Bhuyan 1949, 179-182).

The line between legitimate and illegitimate use of force for political and economic ends was murky in late 18th century Rangpur. The Company was far from being in the possession of a monopoly of violence in the district. It operated an inefficient and corrupt police force, and even its own officials were suspected of misusing their political power for private gain. As a result, private European merchants and indigenous elites at the middle level alike engaged in warlike political contestation, competing for power using real military force in domains nominally claimed by the Company. A thriving mercenary market had cropped up to serve not only these intermediate actors, but also the Company, which relied on the exact same groups to enforce its will at the local level. Mercenary bands were also engaged in banditry, not only in Bengal but also in surrounding states, especially Assam, which had long been subject to centrifugal pressures from civil conflict. Over the course of the late 18th and early 19th centuries, the Company devoted a large amount of effort to truncating these patterns, which were a legacy of the diffuse nature of power in pre-colonial India (Marshall 1987, chs. 4-5); among these was the Welsh expedition, the context behind which is outlined below. But in the moment captured in the evidence

laid out above, the Company was still a thin veneer over top of older patterns. It displayed opportunistic intentions, and even its initial light footprint accelerated resource extraction, leading to the erosion of zamindari authority and other cascading changes (Misra 2018; Misra 2021); but at the turn of the nineteenth century, it was still just one politically salient actor among many others.

Mercenary Flows and Power Struggles on the Goalpara Frontier

In 1791 and early 1792, a series of petitions were taken down by authorities in Goalpara, which alerted the central government in Calcutta to a shadowy world of factional conflict that had been taking place locally without its knowledge. The first of these petitions was from the Derrung raja Krishnarayan. He was a teenage boy whose father had rebelled against the Ahom king and then was allegedly killed in a treacherous manner, after having been invited to an audience on friendly terms. After this, the king attempted to transfer control of the principality to a minor branch of the family. The boy, aided by his father's former allies, as well as European private merchants based in Goalpara, in particular Daniel Rausch, continued his father's rebellion. In his petitions, he solicited the Company's aid, claiming that his forefathers had ruled not only over Derrung but also over a large chunk of the adjacent region, which had in ancient times formed the kingdom of Kamrup. He asked for military support in his quest to resurrect the kingdom, and offered to rule it in the name of the Company, paying a large annual tribute in exchange. He was denied, but the Company also expressed neutrality at his desire to take matters into his own hands, allowing him to gather together a large mercenary force from Rangpur, which he marched into Derrung. Successful in his initial goal, he transformed his campaign into one of conquest, forging deep into Assam and occupying the city of Guwahati, the former capital of Kamrup (Barpujari 2007, 295-299; Bhuyan 1949, 258-280).

Another group of petitioners then appeared in Goalpara, all with complaints targeted at Rausch. One group of complaints, made by customs agents operating at the Assam border on behalf of the king, accused Rausch of kidnapping an Ahom aristocrat, as well as his family, holding them hostage, and stealing 60,000 rupees worth of goods from them (IOR/P/114/57, March 16, 1792, nos. 10-11). Another petition, by two Ahom aristocrats, accused Rausch of heading a large band of mercenaries in a plundering expedition into Assam, supported by 60 Company sepoys and the Company's own military commander stationed at Jugighopa, on the border. They asked the government if they had ordered this (IOR/P/114/57, March 16, 1792, no. 12). A third, made by a vakeel on behalf of the Derrung raja, accused Rausch of forcing him to travel with him to Bengal and holding him there against his will, while simultaneously promising to make him ruler of the whole of Kamrup, after which he escaped and began to collect his mercenary force; it ends with a final plea for support (IOR/P/114/58, June 8, 1792, no. 9).

The Company ordered an investigation into these complaints, with inconclusive results. The Dooariah of Sonapore, whom Rausch was accused of kidnapping, said Rausch was his friend and ally, that he had gone willingly with him to Bengal, and that his real enemies were in the Ahom government. He begged not to be sent back, or he and his family would be killed (IOR/P/114/57, March 16, 1792, no. 13). Answers by European officials stationed in the district all pointed in the same direction: that the only significant body of mercenaries in the area was operating

under the raja of Derrung, and that they had taken some limited military actions using local troops at their disposal, but only in an attempt to disperse them (IOR/P/114/57, March 16, 1792, no. 14; IOR/P/114/57, April 27, 1792, no. 21). Rausch himself answered the accusations against him in a less than circumspect manner, denying them and accusing his enemies, a group of Greek merchants, of angling to displace him, and of conspiring with the Assamese to invent the charges against him (IOR/P/114/57, April 27, 1792, no. 22).

This is a thick maze of claims and counterclaims, difficult to interpret because of their polemic nature. The likeliest possibility is that Rausch, sensing an opportunity to play kingmaker, had helped Krishnarayan to assemble his mercenary force, and perhaps accompanied its early forays into Assam, while at the same time trying to control him, leading to a falling out between the two; the raja of Derrung's petition seems to have stemmed from this soured alliance. Rausch's involvement in the rebellion also likely earned him the enmity of Ahom government officials, who joined together with Ahom revenue officials and a faction of Greek merchants, all of whom were locked in struggles with him over debt payments and control of trade (Bhuyan 1949, 293-300). Subsequent interrogations of Greek merchants active in Goalpara and scrutiny of their seized correspondence revealed that this network of Rausch's detractors submitted their positions at the same time as part of a coordinated plot designed to destroy his influence over trade and politics in the kingdom, so that the Greek merchants could take over his business interests, Assamese merchants and officials could expunge their debts, and he could no longer aid Krishnarayan's rebellion (IOR/P/114/59, July 18, 1792, nos. 9-10).

In the next round of correspondence, however, Rausch appeared as a supporter of the Ahom government against Krishnarayan and his rebels, revealing that he had switched sides for financial reasons - and that the Derrung raja and his mercenaries were now the primary obstacle between him and his new goal, which was to recoup his debts from Ahom aristocrats. His letters were written from Assam, where he was serving as a mediator between two camps, one belonging to the king and the other belonging to the raja, facing each other on opposite sides of the town of Guwahati. He made his intentions clear: the Ahom monarch had invited him in as a negotiator, and he had accepted the offer in the hopes that he could recoup his debts from clients among the Ahom elite, which amounted to nearly 100,000 rupees; but they could not pay as long as Krishnarayan's mercenaries were destroying the whole region, eroding their tax base. When he visited Krishnarayan on behalf of the Ahom government in order to offer him his hereditary seat back in return for peace, the raja agreed but the leaders of his mercenaries refused, saying they would continue fighting until their arrears had been paid, which they fixed at 200,000 rupees (IOR/P/114/58, June 8, 1792, no. 11). The mercenary captains singled out Rausch as the one preventing them from getting paid, suggesting that he at one point may have been involved in financing them (IOR/P/114/62, September 10, 1792, no. 48).

Subsequent letters from Rausch contain assertions that the mercenaries were openly plotting the conquest of Assam, holding the raja they nominally served virtually hostage, dictating the contents of his letters, and that Goalpara itself was in danger of attack (IOR/P/114/62, September 19, 1792, nos. 14-15). Rangmati, a town on the opposite side of the Brahmaputra from Assam, was actually attacked, and the Company resident, as well as the town's chief revenue officer, were killed (Bhuyan 1949, 278). Enclosed alongside these letters are a series of others from the Ahom

monarch and his principal officers repeating the same basic points, urging the Company to aid them in dispersing Krishnarayan's mercenaries (IOR/P/114/58, June 8, 1792, no. 12; IOR/P/114/62, September 10, 1792, no. 49).

The mercenary force Rausch had helped to assemble was apparently out of control, and had taken to terrorizing the countryside - reports describe the fury of the local peasants at these men, so great that if groups of them got separated from the main force they would be surrounded and butchered, their mutilated bodies hung publicly as a warning to the rest (IOR/P/114/57, April 27, 1792, no. 21). What really seems to have attracted the Company's attention however was the open disobedience of the mercenaries, who when asked to return, wrote a tersely worded reply flatly refusing, denying that the Company had any legitimate power over them outside of Bengal (IOR/P/114/62, September 10, 1792, no. 48). The Company took a hard line on this and increasingly devoted more time and resources to the issue (IOR/P/114/62, September 19, 1792, nos. 13-17). They first ordered the mercenaries to return. When there was no response they began to pull whatever levers they had access to, identifying their homesteads, confiscating their property, and even imprisoning their families to use as bargaining chips, but none of this was enough to force them to put down their arms (Johnstone 1877, 16; IOR/P/114/65, November 26, 1792, no. 6).

In their totality, these petitions revealed a troubling underlying fact for the Company: its exercise of sovereignty in the region was partial and limited at best. It was still engaged in a pre-colonial tributary relationship with the raja of Derrung, who was also an erstwhile tributary of the Ahom raja and fighting a fully-fledged war against him using a mercenary army largely raised in Company territory and comprised at least in part of decommissioned sepoys who were suspected of making use of the Company's name. Private European actors in the region, such as Rausch, were also engaged in warlike political contestation with indigenous elites. The mercenaries themselves, who moved in and out of Company territory with impunity, had come to wield significant military power and were accused of using it to extract resources for their own benefit. Their denial of the Company's authority over them in belligerent language appears to have been the final trigger.

As it became increasingly clear that the Company was not fully in control of Goalpara and lacked the resources or knowledge at the local level to secure the kind of authority it desired, it began deliberations to dispatch a body of troops to the region under Captain Thomas Welsh. His orders were directly linked to the issues presented above: to collect information in order to alleviate the Company's ignorance of the Rangpur frontier - the governor-general telling him that without further information, he could not even provide him with proper orders - to restore order to the kingdom of Assam by propping up its unpopular king, and to decommission the burkunadzes, either through negotiation or force, and send them home, which Welsh devoted significant effort to (IOR/P/114/63, October 3, 1792, no. 17; IOR/P/114/65, November 26, 1792, no. 6; IOR/P/114/66, December 17, 1792, nos. 48, 50; IOR/P/114/66, December 21, 1792, no. 17). His success is attested to in a large list of names sent back to Bengal, consisting of Krishnarayan's entire mercenary army, including each man's name (most of them appear to have been Hindus or Muslims from the Gangetic plain) and their rank - starting from the officers and moving down to the lower. Included are each man's arrears: the Company's agreeing to pay them was the main precondition for their surrender (IOR/P/115/6, June 3, 1793, nos. 9, 11).

The Welsh mission was the Company's first attempt to assert real central authority over the Rangpur frontier, many decades after it had begun to collect revenue and claim governance rights over Bengal. The mission represented the intersection of colonial concerns, precolonial patterns and local agency. The Company intended to impose a monopoly of violence over the district, a signature aspect of European notions of sovereignty, in contrast to the layered model typical of precolonial India (Winichakul 1994); but the triggers themselves were in a complex, multisided contest for wealth and power taking place between many different actors, some of whom originated in Company-claimed territory, and some who did not; and in unrestricted movement of large numbers of people across a non-existing border.

Conclusion

The material collected in this article points to the weak, decentralized nature of early Company governance on the Bengal frontier. In the late 18th century, Bengal's borderlands were a place in which the EIC, despite being in power for decades, had little power or legitimacy. Its administration was rudimentary, focused mostly on securing arteries of commercial and agrarian wealth, and it made heavy use of servants of the previous regime, who in many cases continued to administer relationships with border zamindars, rajas and highland groups according to Mughal custom. This arrangement, while efficient in ensuring the upward flow of wealth into the Company's coffers with as little effort as possible, left it lacking even basic knowledge of the fine-grained state of its own borderlands, and unable to control either the exercise of power by non-state actors or the flow of people and goods in and out of the territory it claimed as its own.

The borderland areas of northern Bengal were not fully controlled by Assam, the EIC or any other state. Rather, they formed interlocking spaces in which none had a controlling stake. Company power in northern Bengal seamlessly blended into, and overlapped with, the power of Bhutan, Nepal and Assam, as well as a variety of minor rajas, zamindars and highland tribal chiefs. Much of this space was outside the reach of any state, especially that which was economically marginal and/or located in impassable terrain. In these places, groups thrived which were referred to in many different ways – rebels, refugees, bandits, tribespeople, and wandering castes or clans are just some of the terms one comes across, shifting depending on context but consistently referring to people deemed as problematic because they lived outside state control (and often exercised localized power overlapping with Company-controlled agricultural lands).

Borders, in the sense of lines on a map made real through government enforcement at the ground level, were nowhere to be found; the closest equivalents were a few customs houses or police outposts stationed at key checkpoints. In such a climate, human mobility was torrential and uninhibited. This included merchants, exiles, mercenaries and religious functionaries, who brought with them everything from salt and weapons to intelligence hungrily absorbed by Company officials desperate to know anything at all about the rapidly disintegrating situation to the north.

In such a power vacuum, it is difficult to retroactively draw a definitive line between legitimate and illegitimate use of force. One can trace in the lively, multi-sided political contests of early colonial Rangpur the biographies of bandits who aspired to kingship, European merchants whose thuggish use of force in recouping debts is reminiscent of the tactics of modern gangsters, rajas engaged in rebellion-turned-

conquest and Assamese nobles locked in deathly factionalism over who would control the future of their kingdom and what the relationship of hereditary fiefdoms would be to the center. Presiding over all of this were powerful regional actors such as the EIC, who allied with or suppressed these smaller-scale expressions of power according to their own changing priorities.

The Welsh mission emerged from the survival, many decades into the colonial period, of such patterns of borderland activity, which the Company was submerged in as a successor state to the Mughals. The Company was not the impresario of all of this activity, self-assuredly directing it from above, but rather was sucked into a whirlpool of events not of its own making by powerful currents older than itself. Many of its efforts fell into the category of retroactive damage control: attempts to patch the gaping holes it was beginning to discover in its authority over this frontier. It capitalized where it could on local dynamics in an attempt to secure more control over resources and populations, but these were piecemeal gains won in the moment, more a result of predatory opportunism responding to unfolding events than any grand plan.

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